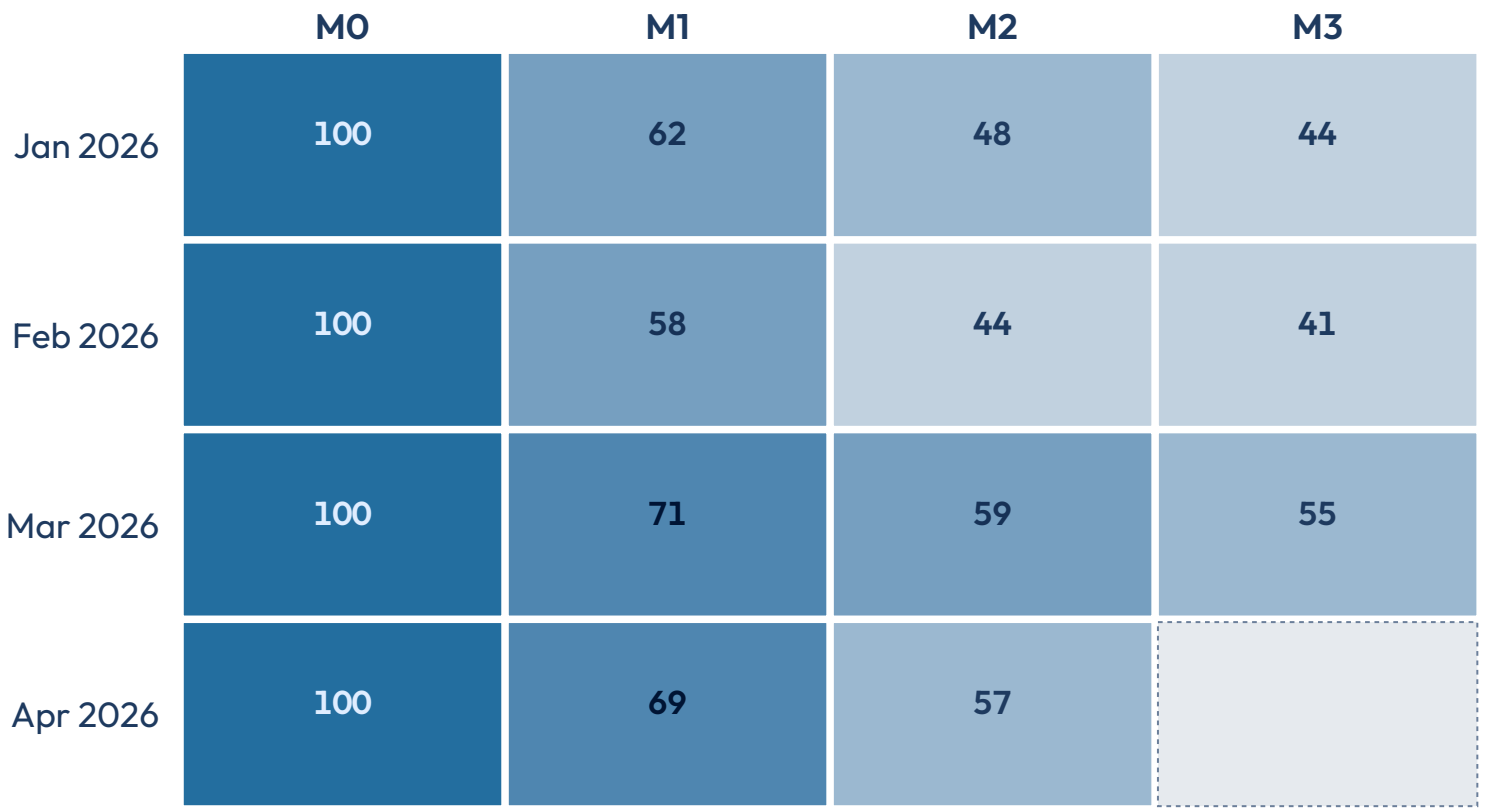
EVIDENCE · CANVAS · SERIES

# heatmap

A numeric matrix read as intensity — where the value concentrates across two dimensions.

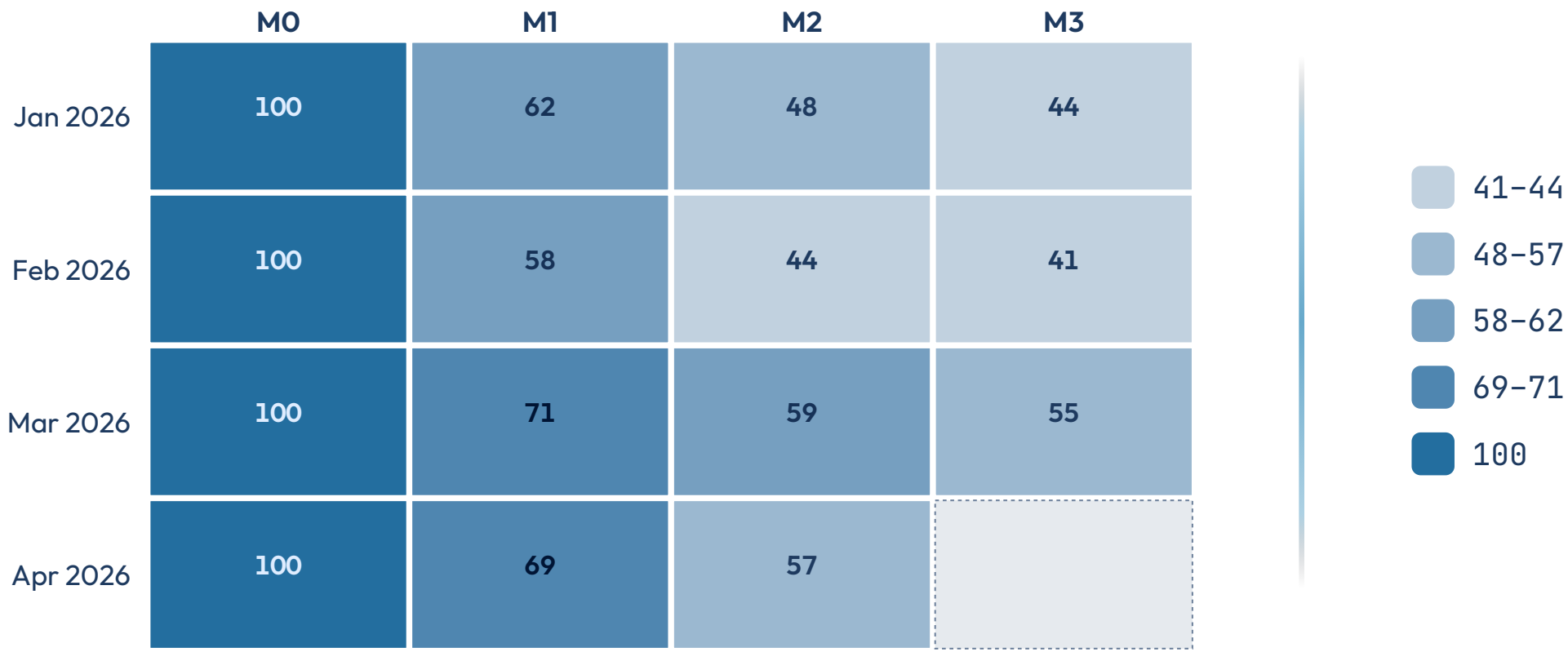
RETENTION · 2026 COHORTS

# Retention decays fastest in month two.



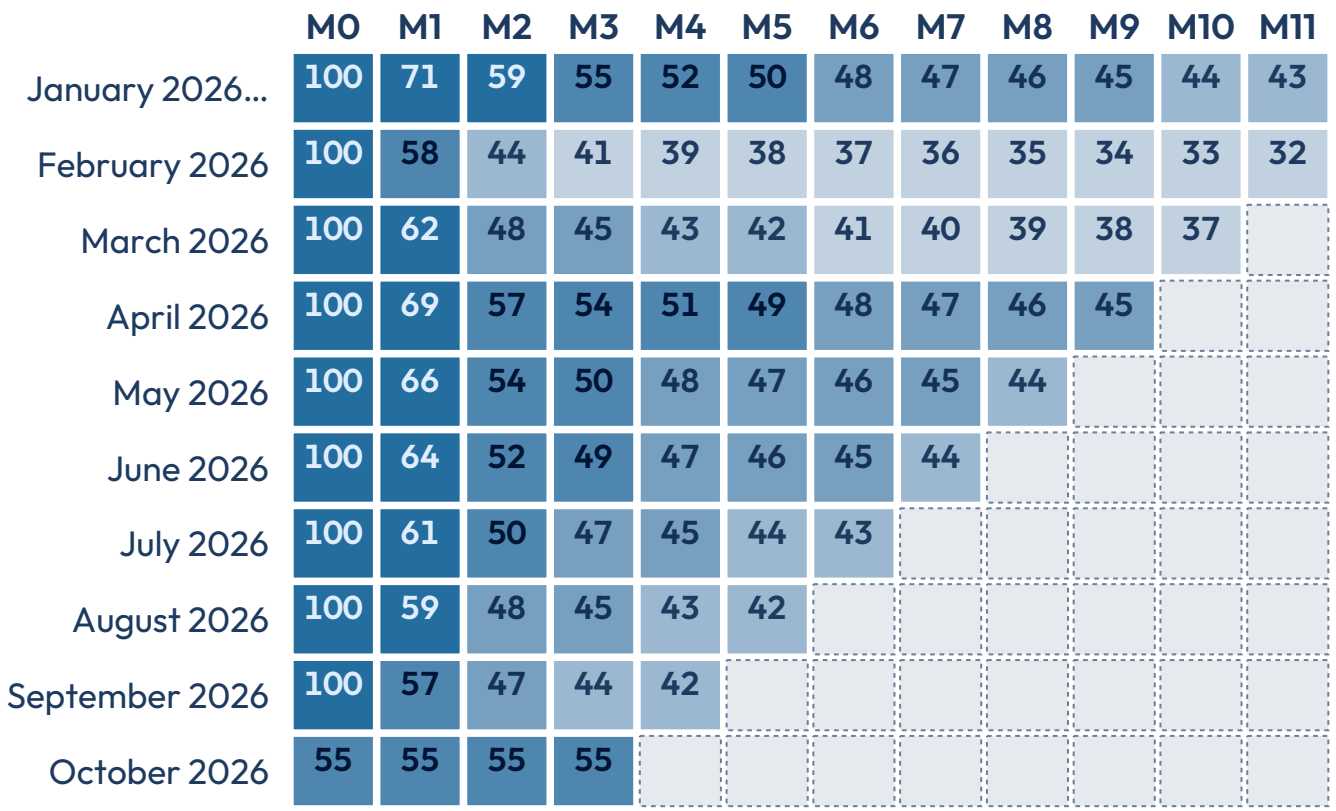
RETENTION · 2026 COHORTS

# The chart names its own bands.



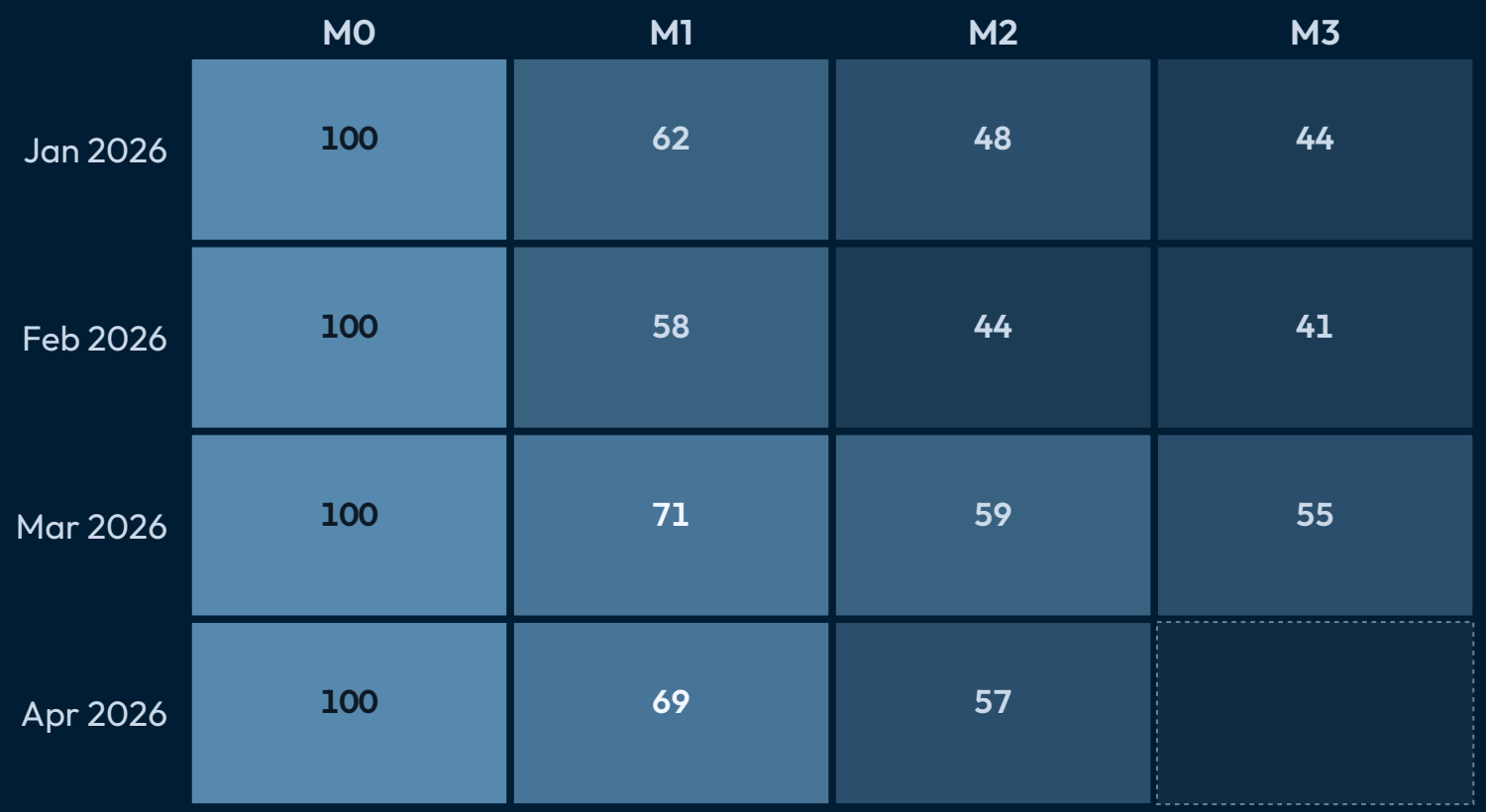
RETENTION · THE CEILING

# Ten cohorts by twelve months — the density this holds.



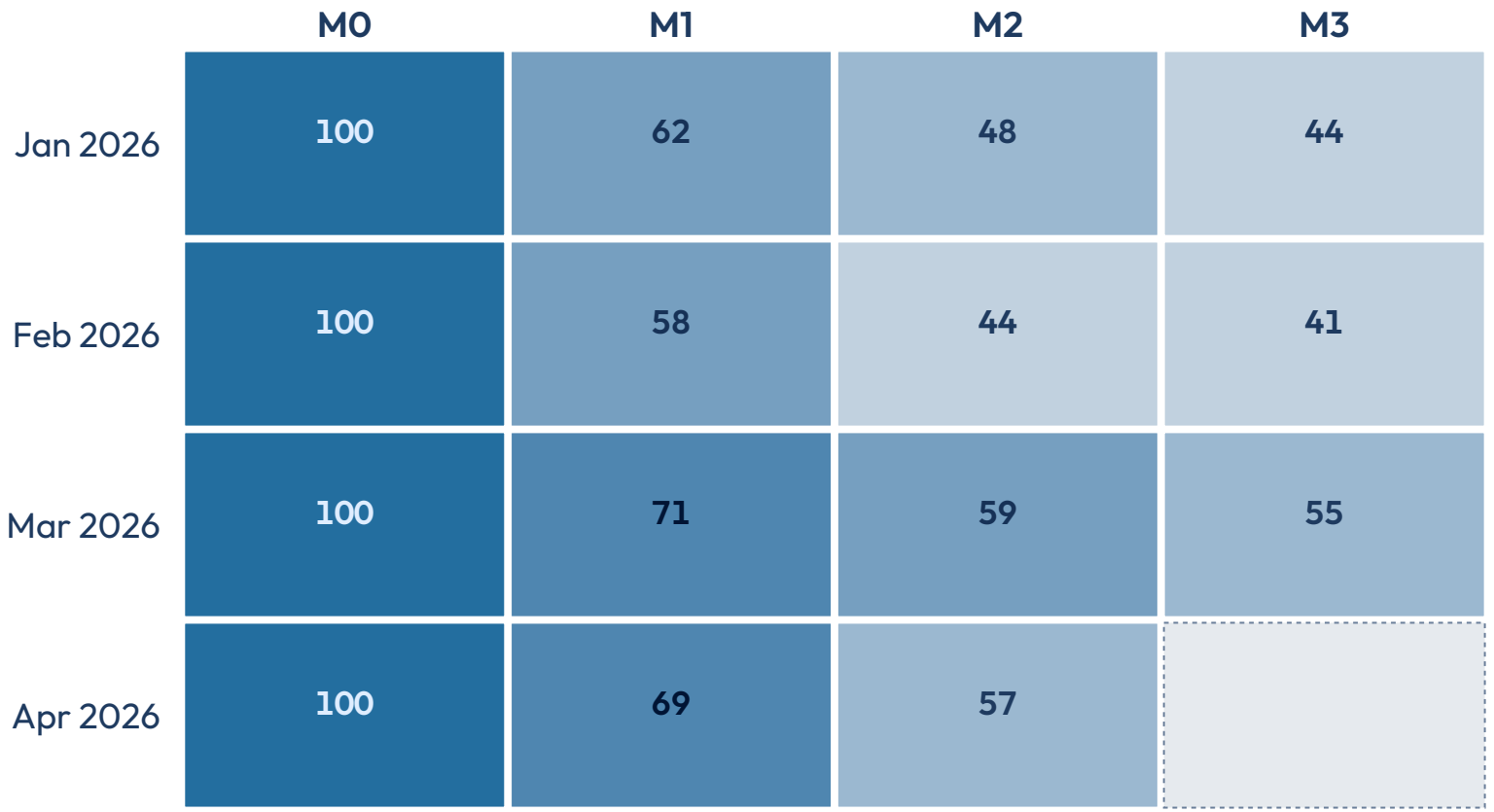
RETENTION · 2026 COHORTS

# Retention decays fastest in month two.



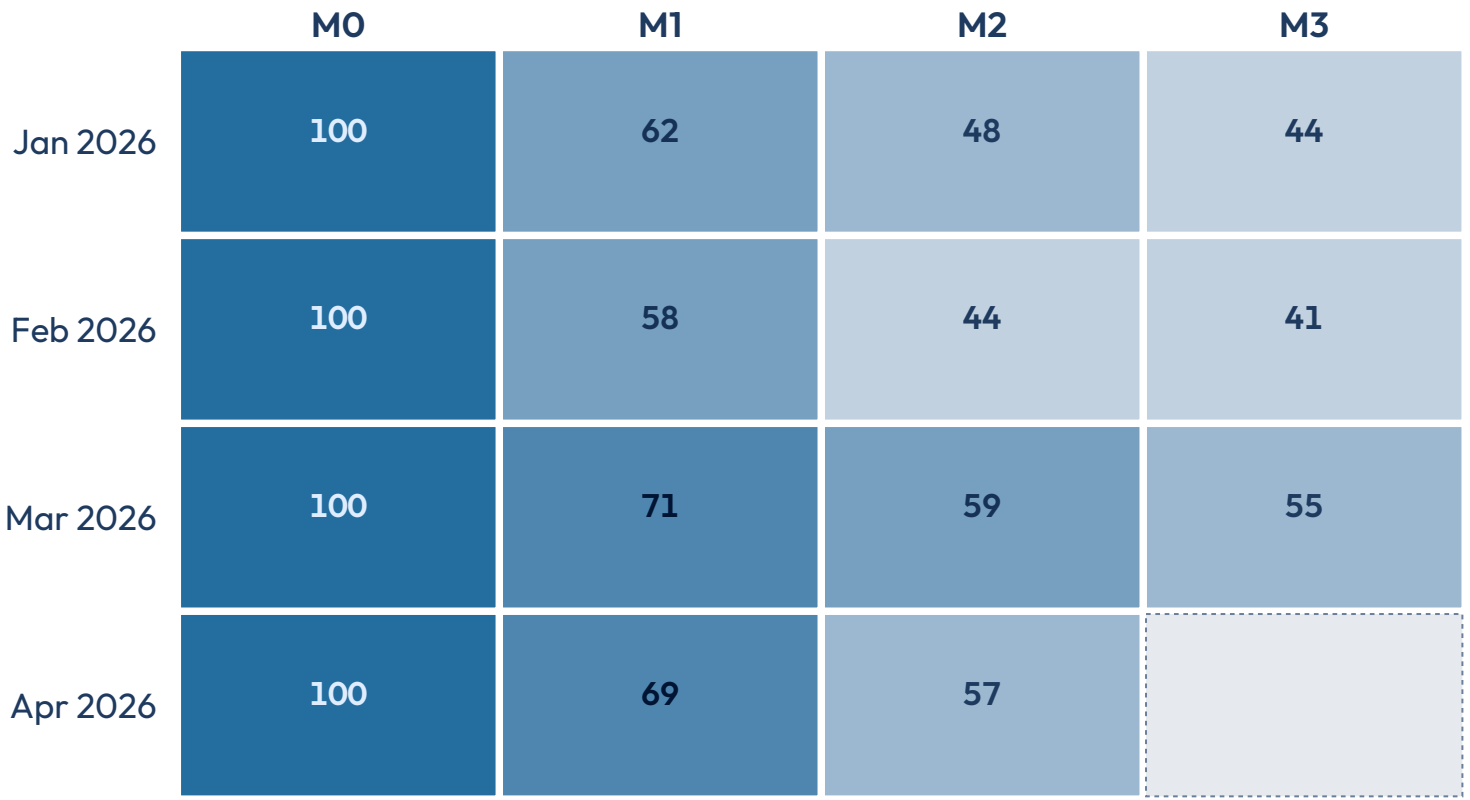
RETENTION · 2026 COHORTS

# Retention decays fastest in month two.



RETENTION · 2026 COHORTS

# Retention decays fastest in month two.



# When NOT to reach for heatmap.

### One row of numbers

A single series is not a matrix — it is a comparison, and a reader judges length far more precisely than intensity. Use `bar`. The kernel declines a one-column table for this reason rather than painting a single strip.

### Qualitative cells

If the cells are verbs, owners or statuses rather than numbers, the ramp has nothing to encode. Use `matrix-grid`, whose cells are tagged at parse time.

# When NOT to reach for heatmap.

**Precise comparison**

Asking a reader which of two similar cells is larger spends the one thing intensity is bad at, and the five-tone binning above makes it stricter: two cells in the same band are the same color by design. If the comparison has to be exact, the value belongs on an axis — `bar` or `line`.

**Geography**

A value per country or region belongs on the `map` choropleth, which shares this ramp but places the cells where the reader expects them.

RELATED COMPONENTS

# See also.

`matrix-grid` — the cells are qualitative — a verb, an owner, a status — rather than a number

`map` — the two dimensions are geographic; same ramp, spatial placement

`bar` — one dimension, and the comparison has to be exact

`quadrant` — two CONTINUOUS axes with items placed on them, rather than two categorical axes with a value at each crossing